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California passes unopposed bill to fight K-12 antisemitism

June 10, 2025 | Jerusalem Post, The (Israel)
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Page: 05
OpenURL Link

A bill to combat antisemitism in K-12 education passed the California State Assembly with a 68-0 vote.

The bill is particularly concerned with protecting students from discrimination, “creating a safe and supportive environment,” and solidifying complaint procedures. After being passed by the Assembly on May 29, the bill moved to the California State Senate to be debated in the Senate Education Committee.

Among other goals, Bill 715 seeks to strengthen protections against discrimination, “including antisemitism,” in K-12 education, with protections against instruction and activity that promotes discrimination. This also covers “discrimination on the basis of religion,” such as Islamophobia and antisemitism.

Subsequently, the bill mandates the appointment of an antisemitism coordinator to further the “intent of and compliance with” Title VI of the Civil Rights Act of 1964. This act states: “No person in the United States shall, on the ground of race, color, or national origin, be excluded from participation in, be denied the benefits of, or be subjected to discrimination under any program or activity receiving federal financial assistance.”

Section 2 of the new bill also seeks to define “nationality” in terms of an individual’s actual or perceived shared ancestry, ethnic characteristics, or residency in a country with a dominant religion or distinct religious identity as provided.

It stipulates that the school boards shall not adopt or allow the use of any textbook, instructional material, or curriculum if the use of these would subject a pupil to unlawful discrimination under Section 220.

The bill was sponsored by four assemblymembers – Dawn Addis, Rick Zbur, Mike Fong, and Jesse Gabriel – as well as three senators, Lena Gonzalez, Akilah Weber Pierson, and Scott Weiner.

This collaboration between the state legislature’s Jewish Caucus and the chairs of the Black, Latino, and Asian Pacific Islander caucuses was due to “a genuine desire to… remedy what’s happening,” Zbur said.

The original bill had the support of 66 Jewish groups, who David Bocarsly, executive director of the Jewish Public Affairs Committee of California, hopes will rally behind the new version.

“In recent years, especially in the aftermath of October 7, we started to see this rise in bias and harmful content existing in other contexts as well,” Bocarsly said.

He cited a ruling by the state Education Department that two teachers in San Jose “discriminated against Jewish students” because they presented one-sided content on the Israeli-Palestinian conflict.

Addis shared that “Jewish families and children have been made, in many instances, to feel unwelcome or made the targets of hate and discrimination in school, where they’re supposed to feel safe and supported. We want to get all the things in place to get back to what schools are supposed to be doing.”

Despite its inclusion of antisemitism and Islamophobia as examples of “discrimination,” the bill has led to significant criticism from Muslim and pro-Palestinian circles.

The California chapter of the Council on American-Islamic Relations condemned the bill, referring to it as “an assault on academic freedom and an attempt to silence voices advocating for Palestinian rights.”

CAIR-CA said that the expanded definition of “nationality” in California’s Education Code to include perceived ancestry, ethnicity, or even religious affiliation tied to a country would prevent criticism of Israel.

“This opens the door to punishing educators who teach about Palestine, colonialism, or human rights abuses, simply because someone claims offense tied to their national or religious identity,” it added.

CAIR-CA CEO Hussam Ayloush said, “The passage of AB 715 is a shameful escalation in the ongoing effort to censor discussions of Palestinian history.

“This bill cloaks censorship in the language of combating antisemitism when, in reality, it is an attempt to erase Palestinian narratives and weaponize identity to chill protected speech.”

Jewish Voices for Peace Action board treasurer Seth Morrison said, “This bill isn’t just censorship; it’s legislative gaslighting.”

He added that AB 715 “exploits the language of civil rights to intimidate educators and erase Palestinian perspectives from the classroom.”

“As a Jew, I reject the idea that opposing genocide and occupation is antisemitic.”

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- **Citation (apa Style)**
  HELLER, M. (2025, June 10). California passes unopposed bill to fight K-12 antisemitism*Jerusalem Post, The (Israel),* p. 05. Available from NewsBank: Access World News – Historical and Current: https://infoweb.newsbank.com/apps/news/document-view?p=WORLDNEWS&docref=news/1A1269C9054B0E88.